Kassym-Jomart Tokayev

(tok-AH-yev)

President of Kazakhstan

Addressed as: **Mr. President** | Office held since: **June 2019**

Kassym-Jomart Tokayev is a career diplomat who has transformed into a decisive leader. His openness to reform is tempered by his need to cement his rule.

- **His Own Man**
  Initially viewed as a figurehead president in the shadow of Kazakhstan's longtime leader Nursultan Nazarbayev, Tokayev gained full control following the January 2022 protests. He stripped Nazarbayev of his title of "Elbasy" (or national patriarch) and ejected his cronies and family from the key government positions.

- **His "New Kazakhstan"**
  Tokayev has touted his economic and political reforms as delivering real change to his country, seeking to cast himself as a reformer at home and abroad. While overseeing some liberalization, he also has adopted many of his predecessor's paternalistic behaviors.

Tokayev is a decisive leader, responding to regime-threatening protests by calling in Russian troops in 2022 and replacing government ministers if they fail to meet set goals. Earlier in his career, he threatened to resign as prime minister unless Nazarbayev removed several cabinet ministers.

WHY THEY MATTER

Tokayev is positioning Kazakhstan as an essential partner for multinational companies seeking to access Eurasian markets and contribute to his diversification agenda.

- **Infrastructure and Regional Integration**
  Tokayev wants to see Kazakhstan as a logistics and infrastructure hub, promoting regional corridors such as the "Trans-Caspian Middle Corridor." He has plugged the Astana International Finance Center (AIFC) as a platform for cross-border finance using a common-law court and arbitration system.

- **Diversification and Digital Transformation**
  He is adamant about diversification, warning that "just relying upon natural resources this way will lead us to the deadlock." He has called for additional support for SMEs and manufacturing, as well as backing for a modern digital architecture.

Tokayev has acknowledged investment challenges, including bureaucratic hurdles, regulatory uncertainties, and the need for judicial reforms. He has hailed his chairmanship of the Foreign Investors' Council as the flagship interface for international engagement.

MEETING WITH THEM

As a former diplomat, Tokayev maintains a calm and measured demeanor whether discussing shared interests or sensitive topics. He seems to value formality and respect over casual friendliness.

- **Future Orientation**
  Tokayev consistently directs conversations toward Kazakhstan's potential and future development, particularly when discussing challenging current realities. He is both self-aware and pragmatic, stating that if a “problem does exist. We need to acknowledge it."

- **Diplomatic Defections**
  When pressed on sensitive topics, he often pivots to comparative arguments ("this happens in other countries too") or appeals to national specificity ("you must understand our historical context").

Tokayev has become more conversational and direct while staying faithful to his years of diplomatic training. His growing confidence has even fostered a willingness, at times, to express personal frustration and criticism.

ON THEIR MIND

- **Economic Growth**
  Kazakhstan's gross domestic product increased by 6.5 percent in January–August 2025, according to the Ministry of National Economy reports. Experts point to positive trends in trade, industry, and communication sectors.

- **U.S. Tariffs**
  The Trump Administration imposed a 25 percent tariff on Kazakhstan in August. The United States has been a major investor in Kazakhstan, primarily for oil and gas development, for decades.

- **Defiance of OPEC+**
  The Energy Minister in April said his country will prioritize national interests over those of the OPEC+ group when determining its oil production levels, implying the country might not comply with cuts it agreed to as part of a supply deal between major producing nations.

- **Parliamentary Reform**
  Tokayev has suggested a return to a unicameral legislature, mirroring the single-chamber Supreme Council of the early post-independence years. He has proposed holding a national referendum on the issue in 2027.

NETWORK

Tokayev has remained true to his predecessor's “multi-vector” foreign policy, leveraging personal and professional experiences with the United States, Russia, and China to promote Kazakhstan’s status as a middle power.

Tokayev–a former Soviet diplomat who studied Chinese in Beijing in the 1980s–asked Russian President Putin to help him put down the protests in 2022 and won praise from Chinese President Xi Jinping as an “old friend.” Despite bilateral tension over U.S. tariffs, Kazakhstan this month welcomed a large delegation of major U.S. companies.

Tokayev has elevated a younger generation of officials following his break with Nazarbayev in January 2022. Even as he assumes more control, he remains relatively popular.

Tokayev has rid himself of those close to Nazarbayev and symbolically distanced himself from the former leader, including by reverting the name of capital from Nur-Sultan back to Astana. He won reelection in 2022 with 81 percent of the vote and signed a bill that established a single, nonrenewable seven-year term that could allow him to serve beyond the two-term limit.

CONTROVERSIES

Tokayev faces criticism for his crackdown on the January 2022 protestors and for detaining opponents, as well as swirling corruption allegations.

- **Repressive Measures**
  Tokayev ordered security forces to “shoot to kill” amid the 2022 unrest; the official death toll is around 230 people. In addition, a veteran human rights defender was detained in August presumably because she was frequently posting about the health of a jailed opposition leader.

- **Graft Allegations**
  According to an OCCRP report, the Tokayev family have opened secretive offshore companies in the British Virgin Islands that controlled a U.K. company with $5 million in assets. They also bought apartments around Lake Geneva and other international capitals worth at least $7.7 million.

Tokayev has become more outspoken about which version of Islam is most appropriate for Kazakhs. In June 2025, Tokayev signed a law banning face-covering (with some exceptions) in public spaces. While supporters frame it as a security measure, critics view it an attack on religious freedom.

CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

- **President**, Government of Kazakhstan (2019 - present)
- **Chairman of the Senate**, Parliament of Kazakhstan (2013 to 2019, 2007 to 2011)
- **UN Under-Secretary-General & Director-General**, UN Office, Geneva (2011 to 2013)
- **Foreign Minister**, Government of Kazakhstan (2002 to 2007, 1994 to 1999)
- **Prime Minister**, Government of Kazakhstan (1999 to 2002)
- **Deputy Foreign Minister**, Government of Kazakhstan (1992 to 1994)
- **Diplomat**, Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR) (1975 to 1991)

BIO

Tokayev's worldview was shaped by extensive international engagement and a multilingual education as his country transitioned from a Soviet Republic to an independent nation. Born May 17, 1953, in Almaty, Tokayev was named after his uncle, who died in WWII. His father who was a decorated war veteran and noted Kazakh writer

- **Writer and Reader**
  Tokayev has written ten books, including a memoir about his father. He regularly posts or recommends books to read including *The Future Is Asian* by Parag Khanna, *21 Lessons for the 21st Century* by Yuval Noah Harari, and *The Industries of the Future* by Alec Ross.

- **Table Tennis Player**
  Tokayev led the Table Tennis Federation of the Republic of Kazakhstan for 13 years and continues to play table tennis to maintain his physical fitness. He earned the title of Candidate Master of Sports during university.

Tokayev is divorced and has a son, although some sources say he also has a daughter. He graduated from Moscow State Institute of International Relations in 1975 and studied Chinese at Beijing Language and Culture University in the 1980s. He is a Muslim and fluent in Kazakh, Russian, Chinese, English, and some French.